Study guide

工作　颜色　篮球　鸡蛋

gōngzuò　yánsè　lánqiú　jīdàn

Study a pattern, change one block, recall it, then write it.

73 expressions, 28 sentences. Seven groups from today’s classroom boards.

01　Meet someone

02　Where, then what

03　Work & everyday negation

04　Sports & reusable phrases

05　Colour families

06　Meat, eggs & powders

07　Recognise the building blocks

Meet someone

Keep the question word where the answer belongs. 哪 nǎ asks “which”; 那 nà points to “that”; 这 zhè points to “this”. 你几岁？ is mainly for young children. 您贵庚？ is very formal and can sound old-fashioned; 你多大了？ is the ordinary classroom form. A polite wording does not make every personal question appropriate.

名字	míngzi name
什么	shénme what
姓	xìng surname; be surnamed
贵姓	guìxìng your surname (polite)
多大	duō dà how old; how big
几岁	jǐ suì how old (usually children)
贵庚	guìgēng your age (very formal)
哪国人	nǎ guó rén from which country
这	zhè this
那	nà that
哪	nǎ which
哪里	nǎlǐ where
哪儿	nǎr where (alternative)

From the classroom board

你叫什么名字?

Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?
What is your name?

Meet someone

From the classroom board

你姓什么?

Nǐ xìng shénme?
What is your surname?

From the classroom board

您贵姓?

Nín guìxìng?
May I ask your surname?

From the classroom board

你多大了?

Nǐ duō dà le?
How old are you?

From the classroom board

你几岁?

Nǐ jǐ suì?
How old are you? (to a child)

From the classroom board

您贵庚?

Nín guìgēng?
May I ask your age? (very formal)

From the classroom board

你是哪国人?

Nǐ shì nǎ guó rén?
Which country are you from?

Where, then what

Subject + 在 + place + action: 我在教室学习。 With no action, 在 can mean “be at”: 我在家。 哪里 and 哪儿 both ask “where”. Put 明天 or 昨天 before the subject or just after it. Contrast locating an activity with 在 directly before a verb, which can mark an action in progress.

家	jiā home; family
超市	chāoshì supermarket
教室	jiàoshì classroom
宿舍	sùshè dormitory
学校	xuéxiào school
公司	gōngsī company
咖啡店	kāfēidiàn café
上海	Shànghǎi Shanghai
苏州	Sūzhōu Suzhou

From the classroom board

你在哪里?

Nǐ zài nǎlǐ?
Where are you?

From the classroom board

你在哪儿?

Nǐ zài nǎr?
Where are you? (alternative)

From the classroom board

我在家。

Wǒ zài jiā.
I am at home.

Where, then what

From the classroom board

你在哪里工作?

Nǐ zài nǎlǐ gōngzuò?
Where do you work?

From the classroom board

我在学校工作。

Wǒ zài xuéxiào gōngzuò.
I work at a school.

From the classroom board

你的公司在哪儿?

Nǐ de gōngsī zài nǎr?
Where is your company?

From the classroom board

在上海。

Zài Shànghǎi.
In Shanghai.

From the classroom board

明天我在苏州工作。

Míngtiān wǒ zài Sūzhōu gōngzuò.
Tomorrow I will work in Suzhou.

From the classroom board

我在教室学习。

Wǒ zài jiàoshì xuéxí.
I study in the classroom.

From the classroom board

我在咖啡店看书。

Wǒ zài kāfēidiàn kàn shū.
I read in a café.

Work & everyday negation

你工作吗？ asks whether someone works. 你做什么工作？ asks what job they do. 我不工作 describes the usual situation; 昨天我没工作 says the action did not happen yesterday. This is a useful contrast, not a rule that every past sentence uses 没 or every future sentence uses 不. 做作业 means “do homework”; 工作 can itself be a verb.

工作	gōngzuò work; job
做作业	zuò zuòyè do homework
学生	xuésheng student
老板	lǎobǎn boss; business owner
工人	gōngrén worker
老师	lǎoshī teacher
医生	yīshēng doctor
大夫	dàifu doctor (another common word)
律师	lǜshī lawyer
律师事务所	lǜshī shìwùsuǒ law firm
学习	xuéxí study; learn
看书	kàn shū read a book

From the classroom board

你做作业吗?

Nǐ zuò zuòyè ma?
Do you do homework?

Work & everyday negation

From the classroom board

你工作吗?

Nǐ gōngzuò ma?
Do you work?

From the classroom board

我不工作。我是学生。

Wǒ bù gōngzuò. Wǒ shì xuésheng.
I do not work. I am a student.

From the classroom board

你做什么工作?

Nǐ zuò shénme gōngzuò?
What do you do for work?

From the classroom board

我是公司老板。

Wǒ shì gōngsī lǎobǎn.
I am a company owner.

From the classroom board

昨天我没工作。

Zuótiān wǒ méi gōngzuò.
I did not work yesterday.

Sports & reusable phrases

Keep 打 + ball sport together: 打篮球, 打网球, 打乒乓球. Build 我喜欢 + activity. Do not add 打 to every sport. In 篮球, 篮 means “basket”; 蓝 means “blue”. The shared 监 is a sound clue in these two characters, while 竹 and ⺮ distinguish their written forms.

喜欢	xǐhuan like
运动	yùndòng sport; exercise
打篮球	dǎ lánqiú play basketball
打网球	dǎ wǎngqiú play tennis
打乒乓球	dǎ pīngpāngqiú play table tennis

From the classroom board

你喜欢什么运动?

Nǐ xǐhuan shénme yùndòng?
What sports do you like?

Additional practice example

我喜欢打篮球。

Wǒ xǐhuan dǎ lánqiú.
I like playing basketball.

Colour families

Colour + 色 makes a reusable colour noun: 红色, 蓝色, 粉色. 色 is not required in every colour expression. 青 covers a context-dependent blue/green range, not one fixed modern colour swatch. 粉色 is pink, but 粉 in 面粉 or 奶粉 means powder: the whole word decides the meaning.

颜色	yánsè colour
彩虹	cǎihóng rainbow
红色	hóngsè red
橙色	chéngsè orange
黄色	huángsè yellow
绿色	lǜsè green
青色	qīngsè blue-green; cyan (context matters)
蓝色	lánsè blue
紫色	zǐsè purple
黑色	hēisè black
白色	báisè white
粉色	fěnsè pink

Additional practice example

我喜欢蓝色。

Wǒ xǐhuan lánsè.
I like blue.

Meat, eggs & powders

Animal + 肉 makes a meat word: 牛肉, 羊肉, 猪肉, 鸭肉. 鸡蛋 is an egg; 鸡肉 is chicken meat. 面粉, 奶粉 and 蛋白粉 share 粉, but name different products. Practise complete words, then change one meaningful block.

鸡蛋	jīdàn egg
鸡肉	jīròu chicken meat
牛肉	niúròu beef
羊肉	yángròu mutton; lamb
猪肉	zhūròu pork
鸭肉	yāròu duck meat
面粉	miànfěn flour
奶粉	nǎifěn milk powder
蛋白粉	dànbáifěn protein powder

Additional practice example

我喜欢吃牛肉。

Wǒ xǐhuan chī niúròu.
I like eating beef.

Recognise the building blocks

亻 is conventionally called 单人旁; 彳 is called 双人旁, but it is not historically “two people”. It relates to steps/walking. 手 often takes the side form 扌; 竹 often appears above as ⺮; 氵 is the water-side form. Components can give meaning or sound clues, not guaranteed definitions. 没 contains 氵, yet its everyday negative meaning is not “water”. 越来越 + adjective describes increasing degree: 越来越好.

江	jiāng river
河	hé river
湖	hú lake
海	hǎi sea
手	shǒu hand
竹	zhú bamboo
笔	bǐ pen; writing brush
篮	lán basket
行	xíng go; be OK (this reading)
走	zǒu walk; leave
超	chāo exceed; surpass
越	yuè exceed; cross
越来越	yuè lái yuè more and more

Additional practice example

我的汉语越来越好。

Wǒ de Hànyǔ yuè lái yuè hǎo.
My Chinese is getting better and better.

Compare before memorising

这 zhè
this

那 nà
that

哪 nǎ
which

篮 lán
basket

蓝色 lánsè
blue

鸡蛋 jīdàn
egg

鸡肉 jīròu
chicken meat

粉色 fěnsè
pink

面粉 miànfěn
flour

奶粉 nǎifěn
milk powder

我不工作。我是学生。 Wǒ bù gōngzuò. Wǒ shì xuésheng.
I do not work. I am a student.

昨天我没工作。 Zuótiān wǒ méi gōngzuò.
I did not work yesterday.

Short reading check - without pinyin

Try saying the meaning and reading aloud. Cover the answer key until finished.

1. 你叫什么名字?
2. 你是哪国人?
3. 你做什么工作?
4. 我在学校工作。
5. 我在咖啡店看书。
6. 昨天我没工作。
7. 你喜欢什么运动?
8. 我喜欢蓝色。
9. 我喜欢吃牛肉。
10. 我的汉语越来越好。

Answer key - check after trying

1. 你叫什么名字？
Nǐ jiào shénme míngzi?
What is your name?

2. 你是哪国人？
Nǐ shì nǎ guó rén?
Which country are you from?

3. 你做什么工作？
Nǐ zuò shénme gōngzuò?
What do you do for work?

4. 我在学校工作。
Wǒ zài xuéxiào gōngzuò.
I work at a school.

5. 我在咖啡店看书。
Wǒ zài kāfēidiàn kàn shū.
I read in a café.

6. 昨天我没工作。
Zuótiān wǒ méi gōngzuò.
I did not work yesterday.

7. 你喜欢什么运动？
Nǐ xǐhuan shénme yùndòng?
What sports do you like?

8. 我喜欢蓝色。
Wǒ xǐhuan lánsè.
I like blue.

9. 我喜欢吃牛肉。
Wǒ xǐhuan chī niúròu.
I like eating beef.

10. 我的汉语越来越好。
Wǒ de Hànyǔ yuè lái yuè hǎo.
My Chinese is getting better and better.